1 Common Ground Challenge

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

In groups of 3-4, find five things everyone has in common, excluding obvious answers such as “we go to the same school”. Each student must suggest at least one possibility. The group may only record an idea after every member confirms it applies to them. Randomly select one student to share the most interesting commonality.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	The group only succeeds with ideas that include everyone.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Every student contributes and anyone may report.
E	**Equal Participation**	One idea each before anyone offers a second.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All groups talk and search at the same time.

2 This or That - Explain Your Choice

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Present a pair of choices: morning or night, city or countryside, books or movies, work alone or with others. Students choose and pair up. Use Timed Pair Share: Partner A has 30 seconds to explain while Partner B listens, then swap. Each student finishes by stating one reason their partner gave.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Each student needs the partner's ideas for the final response.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Both students must speak and listen.
E	**Equal Participation**	Equal speaking time is built in.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	Half the class speaks at once in pairs.

3 Speed Connections

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Students work in pairs with a prompt for 60-90 seconds, then rotate partners. Prompts can deepen gradually: something you enjoy, something you are good at, what helps you learn, or something you want to improve. Split each round into equal turns and finish by finding one connection between the two answers.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Partners share the goal of finding a connection.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone has an assigned speaking turn.
E	**Equal Participation**	Timed turns prevent domination.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	Every pair interacts simultaneously.

4 Find Someone Who...

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Give students prompts such as: speaks more than one language, enjoys cooking, has travelled somewhere interesting, prefers group work, or has an unusual hobby. Students may use each classmate only once and must ask one follow-up question before recording a name. Afterwards, in groups of four, each student shares one interesting thing they learned.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Students depend on classmates to complete the task.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Each student gathers and reports their own information.
E	**Equal Participation**	One-name-only rule broadens participation.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	The whole class questions and responds at once.

5 Four Corners

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

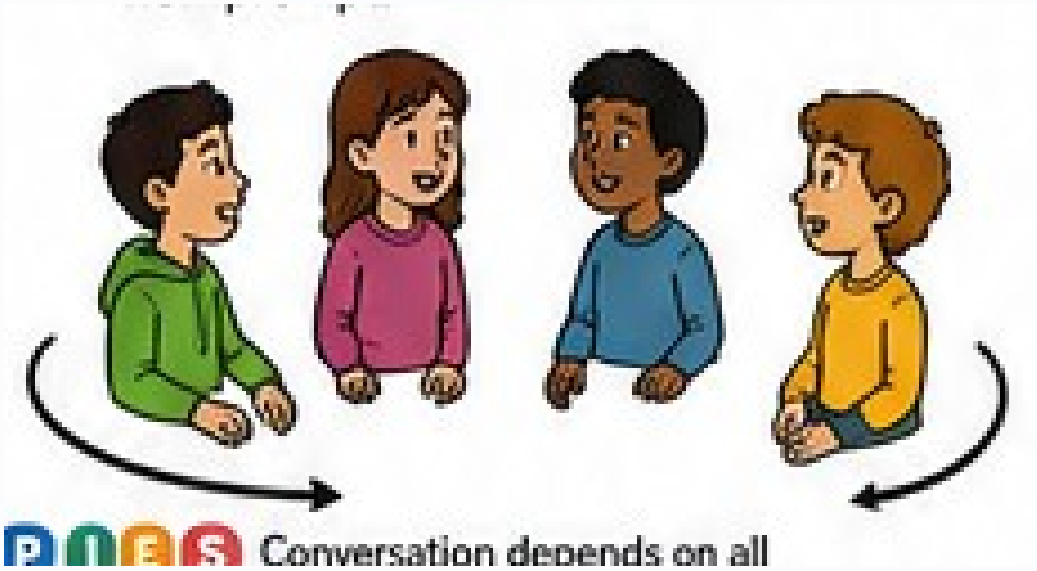
Assign four responses to the room corners, for example: What helps you learn best? Seeing it, hearing it, discussing it, or doing it. Students move to a corner, then form groups of 3-4. Use Round Robin: each student has 30 seconds to explain. The group creates one shared statement, and a spokesperson is selected at random.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	The group combines ideas into one shared statement.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone explains and anyone may be spokesperson.
E	**Equal Participation**	Round Robin gives everyone a turn.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	Many small groups discuss at the same time.

6 Question Circle

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Use groups of four rather than one whole-class ball. Student A asks Student B a getting-to-know-you question; B answers and asks C a new or follow-up question, continuing around the circle. After one round, reverse direction or introduce a new prompt. Every student both asks and answers.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	The conversation depends on each person keeping it moving.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Every student must ask and answer.
E	**Equal Participation**	Turns are structured and evenly shared.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	Several circles talk simultaneously.

7 Two Truths and a Stretch

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

In groups of four, one student shares three statements: two true and one deliberately exaggerated or invented. The other students first choose individually which statement is the “stretch”, then take turns explaining why. The group must reach a consensus before the answer is revealed. Rotate until everyone has presented.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	The group must reach a shared decision.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone commits to an answer and explains it.
E	**Equal Participation**	Every student presents and responds.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All groups play simultaneously.

8 Conversation Cards

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Place open-ended prompt cards on tables. In groups of four, Student A draws a card and answers for up to 30 seconds. Student B must ask a follow-up question. After A answers, B draws the next card and Student C becomes the questioner. Continue so every student answers and asks.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Roles connect one student's response to another's question.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone must answer and ask.
E	**Equal Participation**	Roles rotate so opportunities are equal.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All groups hold conversations at once.

9 Would You Rather? + Convince Me

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Give an age-appropriate dilemma such as more time or more money, team or independent work, beach or city. Pair students with someone who chose differently whenever possible. Use Timed Pair Share: each has 45 seconds to persuade. Finish by identifying the strongest argument from the opposite position.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Each student needs the partner's argument for the final task.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Both students present and listen.
E	**Equal Participation**	Equal persuasion time is guaranteed.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All pairs debate simultaneously.

10 Student-to-Student Interviews

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

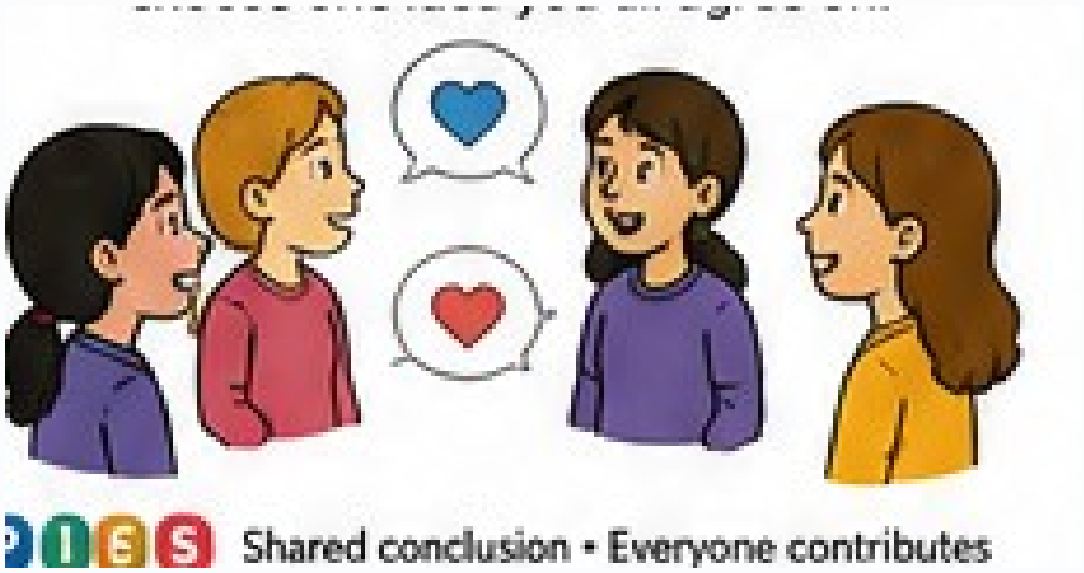
Pair students and provide 4-5 broad questions about interests, strengths, goals and learning preferences. Give each student two minutes as interviewer. Then join two pairs together. Each student has 30 seconds to introduce their partner to the other pair, and the partner may add or clarify one point.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Success depends on listening well enough to represent a partner.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone interviews, answers and introduces.
E	**Equal Participation**	Timed roles give equal opportunities.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	Interviews happen across the room at once.

11 Connection Circles

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

In groups of four, respond to one prompt at a time, such as: something I am looking forward to, something that makes a good class, or something teachers can do that helps me learn. Use Round Robin. Before giving their own response, each student must connect to the previous speaker. Finish by agreeing on one shared idea.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	Students work toward a shared conclusion.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Everyone contributes and must listen to the previous speaker.
E	**Equal Participation**	Structured turns distribute the conversation.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All circles discuss simultaneously.

12 My Top Three

A cooperative-learning activity built on PIES



How to run it

Give a category such as foods, places, hobbies, songs, qualities of a good teacher, or ways you like to learn. Students first create an individual Top 3. In groups of four, everyone shares their number one choice and reasoning before open discussion. The group then agrees on a collective Top 3 using ideas from at least three different members.

How it meets PIES

P	**Positive Interdependence**	The group must combine ideas into one outcome.
I	**Individual Accountability**	Individual thinking happens before discussion.
E	**Equal Participation**	Everyone shares before open discussion.
S	**Simultaneous Interaction**	All groups rank and negotiate at the same time.